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## BUDGET BREAKDOWN

# WHAT PRO VISUALS ACTUALLY COST (AND WHY)

As an independent artist planning your own visual shoots, it can seem impossible to get transparent pricing, clarity on what you actually need, what it actually costs, and why. This document changes all of that.

4I RECORDS    UPDATED SEPT 2026    FOUR BUDGET TIERS

We lay out what filmmaking personnel, equipment, and post-production you can afford and expect according to your budget.

## THE FOUR BUDGET TIERS

| TIER 1             | TIER 2                 | TIER 3                    | TIER 4            |
|--------------------|------------------------|---------------------------|-------------------|
| <b>NO BUDGET</b>   | <b>SMALL BUDGET</b>    | <b>MEDIUM BUDGET</b>      | <b>BIG BUDGET</b> |
| <b>\$0 – \$500</b> | <b>\$500 – \$4,000</b> | <b>\$4,000 – \$10,000</b> | <b>\$10,000 +</b> |

If you're here, we're going to assume you fall into the first three categories, but 4i Productions can help you no matter what budget you're working with.

**Three things every music video needs:** an artist, a camera, and an editor. You can be all three.

Here's how that looks.

### Tier 1 NO BUDGET

- ☐ Filmed on iPhone or camera at home
- ☐ Edited by yourself with tutorials and free assets you can find online (like [graicekay.gumroad.com](https://www.graicekay.com))
- ☐ Grab a friend to film for you, or set up a tripod
- ☐ Get super creative and have fun

If you're operating with a bit more money, you can get other creatives involved who want to work on passion projects for their portfolio. Collaborating with other talented independent creatives can increase the production value and make production go by way more smoothly.

## Tier 2 SMALL BUDGET

- ☐ Get together a crew of volunteer filmmakers and use the equipment you can find or afford
- ☐ Set up a real shoot day with crafty on set
- ☐ Edit yourself, or find a volunteer editor
- ☐ Minimal lighting, camera, costume, and location, sourced through sites like Facebook Marketplace and Peerspace [see the resource list below](#)

At this stage, you can wear fewer hats and have fun with a more experienced group of creative professionals while keeping other costs (location, costumes, etc.) lower — or spend more budget on more expensive equipment with fewer people involved. It depends on your level of comfort, knowledge, and experience with filmmaking.

## Tier 3 MEDIUM BUDGET

- ☐ Hire a real DP and director with a good camera and lighting package
- ☐ Secure some locations at a well-priced day rate
- ☐ Secure volunteer filmmakers and extra actors who can help on set at a discounted rate
- ☐ Hire an editor to cut the finished video, and/or cut clips for social media promotion
- ☐ Hire a professional BTS photographer or videographer so you have great content for socials
- ☐ Splurge on costumes, maybe a makeup artist
- ☐ Make sure you're following permit and filming laws in your local area

At this level, you can realize a grand-scale vision with lots of qualified professionals to handle the logistics of planning and executing your visual music project.

#### Tier 4 **BIG BUDGET**

- ☐ Experienced professional director
- ☐ Professional assistant director to keep the shoot running smoothly
- ☐ Director of photography with a professional camera package
- ☐ Other camera operators for multicam shooting
- ☐ Catering and crafty for grip and lighting crew
- ☐ Professional set design and lighting equipment
- ☐ Location, prop, and costume rentals
- ☐ Makeup artists

## WHAT ARE EXPECTED RATES?

For production roles, most creatives charge via **day rate** — the amount of money they'll want per day of shooting. If you only shoot for one day, you pay them for one day, but most large-scale music videos shoot for two days or more.

What you can expect:

- **Professional DP or director** — day rates range from \$200 (someone starting out that you struck a deal with) to \$1,000+ (working professionals).
- **Camera package** — you can rent a great camera for a few hundred dollars a day, but keep in mind that to get the beautiful cinematic shots you want, you'll also need to rent the specific lenses, lighting equipment, and silks or screens to achieve the look.
- **Grip and gaff crew** — you'll want people on set to move lights, set up safe rigging, help operate equipment, or even just hold lights by hand for guerilla setups. The day rate for gaff and grip crew varies by budget tier: \$100 to \$2,000 is a low-end to high-end range.
- **Assistant directors** — the same range applies. ADs are very helpful for managing the flow and scheduling of crew, and tracking shot list and coverage progress.
- **Editors** charge hourly or per project, not by the day. An entry-level editor doing this project for a portfolio credit could charge a couple hundred dollars for a finished music video, or could charge hourly. Editor hourly rates range from \$20 to \$200+ an hour.

| DAY RATE RANGES               |  |                  |                                             |
|-------------------------------|--|------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| DP / DIRECTOR<br>PER DAY      |  | \$200 - \$1,000+ | GRIP & GAFF CREW<br>PER DAY, EACH           |
| ASSISTANT DIRECTOR<br>PER DAY |  | \$100 - \$2,000  | CAMERA PACKAGE<br>PER DAY, W/ LENSES        |
| EDITOR<br>PER HOUR            |  | \$20 - \$200+    | EDITOR, PER PROJECT<br>PORTFOLIO-RATE FLOOR |

#### PRO TIP

4i Productions works with creatives in Salt Lake City, Los Angeles, and New York, and editors from all around the world, to get you the best rates for your project in any budget tier.

[GET YOUR FREE QUOTE TODAY →](#)

## WHERE TO GET THE MOST BANG FOR YOUR BUCK

### 1 LIGHTING

A lot of people think a more expensive camera equals better production value, but it's not true. Most filmmakers will agree the best investment you can make is in lighting — or in creative professionals who are trained to see and arrange shots according to natural lighting.

#### PRO TIP

This music video was shot on an iPhone for \$60 — the cost of an iPhone stabilizer from Amazon.

Even if you can't afford expensive lights, training the eye to see composition and good lighting helps elevate the perceived production value of your visual project dramatically. In that case, hiring an experienced DP may be worth it even without an expensive camera or lighting package.

### 2 EDITING

Others might argue your best investment is in editing. Taking even poorly-lit iPhone footage and adding color grading, graphics, and some VFX in post can make your visuals look intentional and creative. Editing is also where you have the most creative freedom to try new visual directions, hooks, effects, and more.

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CREATIVITY

One thing that money can't buy: creativity, passion, and authenticity. A music video at any budget can be an incredible piece of art by being an honest expression of you, the artist. Remember to enjoy the process — the best music video is one made by you, with the tools you have available, while authentically expressing yourself.

It can be overwhelming to watch hours and hours of filmmaking and editing tutorials. If you'd rather focus on making music, 4i Productions works with talented editors all over the world to get you the most qualified editor for the job at a price that fits within your budget.

[GET YOUR FREE QUOTE TODAY →](#)

BUILD YOUR OWN BUDGET

With all that said, here's a fillable production table that works at any budget. Pick an option for each role and mix and match to see what your project would actually run.

| PRODUCTION<br>NEED | A - DO IT YOURSELF                                       | B - DISCOUNTED / EMERGING                                         | C - HIRE A PROFESSIONAL                           |
|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| DIRECTOR           | <div>A</div> Self-direct, or a friend cheap/free<br>\$0  | <div>B</div> Experienced indie filmmaker, discounted<br>\$200-500 | <div>C</div> Hire a professional<br>\$500-1,250   |
| DP                 | <div>A</div> Friend films you, or set up a tripod<br>\$0 | <div>B</div> DP taking it on as a portfolio builder<br>\$200-500  | <div>C</div> Hire a professional<br>\$1,000-1,800 |
| GAFF & GRIP        | <div>A</div> Skip entirely<br>\$0                        | <div>B</div> Film students or enthusiastic techs<br>\$100-400     | <div>C</div> Hire professionals<br>\$400-2,000    |
| AD                 | <div>A</div> Do it yourself<br>\$0                       | <div>B</div> Someone at a discounted rate<br>\$100-300            | <div>C</div> Hire a professional<br>\$300-800     |

|                                                                                      |                                                                              |                                                                                 |                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LIGHTING                                                                             | <div>A</div> <div>Natural light, or what you have</div> <div>\$0</div>       | <div>B</div> <div>Cheap rental house, or second-hand</div> <div>\$50–250</div>  | <div>C</div> <div>Professional lighting package</div> <div>\$300–1,200</div>   |
| CAMERA                                                                               | <div>A</div> <div>Phone or camera you own</div> <div>\$0</div>               | <div>B</div> <div>Library, student house, cheap rental</div> <div>\$0–150</div> | <div>C</div> <div>Professional camera package</div> <div>\$300–800</div>       |
| EDITING                                                                              | <div>A</div> <div>Yourself, or a friend free/discounted</div> <div>\$0</div> | <div>B</div> <div>4i Productions artist rate</div> <div>\$200–600</div>         | <div>C</div> <div>Pro editor, years of experience</div> <div>\$800–2,500</div> |
| BALLPARK PER SHOOT DAY    All A \$0    All B \$850 – 3,300    All C \$3,300 – 10,350 |                                                                              |                                                                                 |                                                                                |

AUTOCALCULATE

Open [4i-budget-estimator.xlsx](#) in this folder — pick A, B or C per role and the total calculates itself. Or use the live version at [4irecords.com/resources/what-pro-visuals-cost](#).

## FREE & CHEAP ARTIST RESOURCES

Where to actually find the locations, gear, crew, and assets referenced above.

| RESOURCE  | WHAT IT'S FOR                                                                                   | COST                   |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| LOCATIONS | <b>Peerspace</b> — hourly rentals of studios, homes, lofts, warehouses                          | Hourly, varies         |
|           | <b>Giggster</b> — film-specific location marketplace, built for productions                     | Hourly or daily        |
|           | <b>Facebook Marketplace &amp; local groups</b> — direct-message owners of spaces you've spotted | Negotiable             |
|           | <b>Your city or county film office</b> — permits, and often free public locations               | Free to low permit fee |

| RESOURCE                 | WHAT IT'S FOR                                                                                                               | COST                            |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <b>GEAR</b>              | Your public library — many lend cameras, lenses, tripods, and lights                                                        | Free                            |
|                          | <a href="#">ShareGrid</a> — peer-to-peer camera and lighting rental from local owners                                       | Daily, below rental-house rates |
|                          | <a href="#">Fat Llama</a> — peer-to-peer rental for gear of all kinds                                                       | Daily                           |
|                          | Your local film school — student equipment checkout if you or a crew member is enrolled                                     | Free to students                |
|                          | <a href="#">Craigslist</a> — discounted second-hand gear, and local open calls for crew                                     | Varies                          |
| <b>CREW &amp; CAST</b>   | Film school Facebook and Discord groups — where students look for portfolio work                                            | Free to discounted              |
|                          | <a href="#">Actors Access</a> — casting calls, free to post                                                                 | Free to post                    |
|                          | <a href="#">Backstage</a> / <a href="#">Mandy</a> — casting and crew calls                                                  | Posting fee                     |
|                          | Your own socials — a crew call post is the highest-yield thing on this list                                                 | Free                            |
| <b>POST &amp; ASSETS</b> | <a href="#">graicekay.gumroad.com</a> — free editing assets, presets, and overlays                                          | Free                            |
|                          | <a href="#">Pexels</a> , <a href="#">Pixabay</a> , <a href="#">Freesound</a> — free stock footage, stills, and sound design | Free                            |

## FILMMAKER VOCAB

|          |                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DP       | Director of Photography — also called the videographer or cinematographer. Runs the camera and the look of the image.                                                                 |
| AD       | Assistant Director — the person who runs scheduling, the shot list, and crew management.                                                                                              |
| CLT      | Chief Lighting Technician — the head gaffer, the person in charge of lighting. A very important art form; works closely with the DP to make your shots look good.                     |
| GAFFER   | The electrician who builds and runs the lighting setup under the CLT or DP.                                                                                                           |
| GUERILLA | Shooting fast, small, and mobile — minimal gear, minimal crew, often without permits or a locked location. A style, not a compromise.                                                 |
| RIGGING  | The hardware and setup that holds lights, cameras, and grip equipment safely in place — stands, clamps, trusses, mounts. Bad rigging is the most common way people get hurt on a set. |

|                 |                                                                                                                                   |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| GRIP            | Crew who rig and move everything that shapes or supports light and camera — stands, flags, silks, dollies.                        |
| DAY RATE        | What a crew member charges per day of shooting, regardless of hours. The standard unit for production roles.                      |
| CAMERA PACKAGE  | The camera plus everything it needs to actually shoot — lenses, media cards, batteries, monitor, support.                         |
| SILKS & SCREENS | Fabric and reflective panels used to soften, bounce, or block light. Cheap, and they do more for your image than a better camera. |
| CRAFTY          | The snack and drink table on set. Not optional — a fed crew works better and comes back.                                          |
| CALL SHEET      | The document sent out before a shoot day with times, locations, contacts, and who's needed when.                                  |
| BTS             | Behind the scenes — footage and stills of the shoot itself, which becomes most of your social content.                            |
| COLOR GRADING   | The post-production pass that sets the final look and mood of the footage.                                                        |
| VFX             | Visual effects — anything added or altered in post that wasn't in front of the camera.                                            |
| COVERAGE        | The set of angles and takes you shoot for a moment, so the editor has options to cut with.                                        |

## 4I PRODUCTIONS IS HERE TO HELP AT ANY STEP OF THE PROCESS

Whether you need some quick social clips edited or the whole production process taken care of, we'll find the best quote for you as an independent artist on a limited budget.

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Rates are 2026 market estimates, not quotes.